Art Imitates Life's Imitation of Art

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This artist's talk describes the undertaking of a project with a working name of 'Vital Presence' at a large government funded research institution somewhere in Japan. To maintain anonymity as requested, the artist is herein referred to as *Frankenstein-san*, his collaborators as *Igor1-san, Igor2-san, Igor3-san, . . . Igor6-san* respectively. The Institute shall be likewise referred to as *The Bunker*.

Frankenstein-san was fortunate enough to have an exhibition in Paris[1] when he met the president of *The Bunker*. The President liked *Frankenstein-san's* work and arranged for him to visit *The Bunker* as visiting researcher and artist. The objective was to make an interactive virtual world where music was produced using the genetics and behaviours of artificial organisms. The *Vital Presence* project was so named because the artist wanted to make artefacts that leave the observer with the feeling of being in the presence of a living thing. Such artefacts could exist somewhere at the boundary between animate and inanimate, the world of the made and the world of the born. Exploiting the power of sound as a vital sign, a number of experimental musical environments were produced.

Igor1-san and *Igor2-san*, two student intern researchers from USA and Canada, wrote the first world on a Silicon Graphics O2 workstation. This world had some interesting features but also some serious flaws due to inexperience of the artist and programmers. The second world was made in collaboration with *Igor3-san*, a young Computer Science student from Canada, and *Igor4-san*, an alife composer and veteran MDI tinkerer from Sweden. This collaboration went much better and resulted in a surreal landscape that the user navigates with a joystick and allows intervention in the life of the creatures. Running under Windows 98, user can pick up creatures and take them to food or induce them to mate with another creature to practice a crude form of musical eugenics[2].

The third world was made as a development on the second one, but quickly became a separate project. In this project, *Frankenstein-san's* collaborators were *Igor5-san*, an energetic computer science lecturer from *Clayton's University*[3] in Australia and *Igor6-san*, a graduate student in computer science from Thailand who attended university in the USA. This world employs a more abstracted spherical depiction of the world and the creatures themselves are animated splotches of colour reminiscent of the strokes of impressionist painters. Interaction is more rarefied, involving mostly moving around and listening. It is intended that the user eventually be able to paint in patches of colour on the sphere with a drawing tablet. Creatures may be affected in unpredictable ways by these colours depending on their genetic makeup. Emphasis is more on slight perturbations of a continuous system rather than direct manipulation or control.

If time permits, *Frankenstein* will also describe other projects undertaken by him at *The Bunker*, including a mixed reality midi interface and a 3d camera tracking movement interface.

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[1] This was a presentation of an earlier alife music work produced in Australia in the late 1990s.
[2] The word *eugenics* got a lot of bad press, what with Hitler and all that, but we prefer to call it 'weeding God's garden'.
[3] Not the university's real name of course.